

Getting Recommended

How AI assistants and travel platforms decide which Barcelona walking tours to put in front of people — and what to change, across the OTAs and the website, so we are one of them.

THE ONE IDEA

AI and OTA search do not invent recommendations — they surface what is already validated, findable, and clearly different across many sources. So the whole game is four moves: be **validated** (reviews), be **findable** (the right words, complete listings), be **different** (one sharp edge), and be **consistent** (the same message everywhere). Everything below is those four.

01 — THE LANDSCAPE

Three funnels, one engine underneath

People find a Barcelona tour three ways now, and all three run on the same engine — a search index of **third-party** pages:

- **AI assistants** — ChatGPT, Perplexity, Google's AI answers. They read the web and hand back a shortlist or a comparison table.
- **OTA search** — GetYourGuide, Viator, GuruWalk, and their internal 'best walking tours in Barcelona' ranking.
- **Classic search & word of mouth** — Google results, travel blogs, Reddit, TripAdvisor.

The important part: the AI assistants and the search engines **ground their answers on the same sources** — OTA 'best of' pages, review sites, aggregators, listicle blogs, forums. They almost never quote a tour company's own website. So the OTAs and the website are not separate projects — improving the OTA listings is also how you improve the AI answers.

02 — THE MECHANICS

How an AI actually builds its list

It is not magic and it is not random. In order:

- **It reads the question's shape.** 'Free walking tour' is not 'guided tour' is not 'first-day walking route'. Each pulls a different answer (one phrasing returned a do-it-yourself itinerary and no operator at all).
- **It gathers a shortlist** from the third-party sources it trusts for that query.
- **It ranks** by review signals, source authority, how well the wording matches the query, recency, and whether there is a clear reason to include each one.
- **It presents** a ranked list or table — often with a 'why it is good for first-timers' column. That column is the whole battle.

We tested this live with five real prompts. The result was consistent, and worth sitting with:

Prompt we tested	What the AI surfaced	Us?
'Best free walking tour Barcelona, first-time visitor'	Runner Bean, Sandeman's, GuruWalk tours — an Old City / Gothic list	No
'One walking tour for my first day...'	A DIY itinerary tracing our exact route; ended 'if you prefer a guide, look for tours titled...' — unnamed	No
'Best rated walking tour, local guide'	OTA 'best of' pages, WithLocals, a Nomadic Matt listicle	No
'Is it worth it / Reddit'	TripAdvisor, Expedia, Wanderlog, a Time Out list	No
'Covers Sagrada Família and Gaudí, small group'	Runner Bean's Gaudí tour, Barcelona Free Tours, U.S. News	No

Live prompts run against Perplexity and the web index it grounds on, September 2026.

Three lessons fell out of it, and they drive the rest of this document.

LESSON 1 — CATEGORY

The default 'free walking tour Barcelona' means an **Old City / Gothic Quarter** tour in the AI's mind. Our Sagrada → Gaudí → Gothic route is a different shape, so we get filed out of the default list unless we are explicit about what we are.

LESSON 2 — GROUNDING

It cites **third-party** sources — OTA pages, review sites, listicles, forums — not our website. Being brilliant on our own site helps only the fraction of AIs that fetch it. To move the needle you have to be present, and strong, where they already look.

LESSON 3 — RANKING

Winners lead on '**established / locally founded / strong storytelling / consistently rated**'. We cannot claim longevity — we are new. So we win on the two things we can control: a sharper differentiator, and a growing pile of recent reviews.

03 — THE OTA ENGINE

What actually moves OTA ranking

The OTA 'best of' pages are the single most-cited source across every test. Ranking on them is worth more than any other single thing. Here is what their algorithms weigh, and the lever for each:

Factor	Why it matters	Your lever
Reviews — count, score & recency	The biggest signal, and how a new operator overtakes an old one over time. Recent reviews are weighted heavily.	Ask every happy guest, every tour. Steady beats sporadic.
Conversion — bookings / views	A listing people actually book gets pushed to more people. A flywheel.	Sharp title, strong first line, real photos.

Factor	Why it matters	Your lever
Completeness	Half-filled listings are down-ranked; the platform cannot match them to as many searches.	Fill every field — stops, inclusions, languages, policy, photos.
Keyword relevance	The title and first lines are matched to the traveller's search words.	Front-load 'Sagrada Família, Gaudí, Gothic Quarter, small group, local'.
Reliability	Fast replies, low cancellations and honoured bookings feed a hidden quality score.	Respond quickly; never cancel on a guest.
Category tags	Each tag is another filtered 'best of' list you can appear on.	Tick Walking, Historical, Small-Group, Cultural, City tours.

The ready-to-paste titles, descriptions and keyword lists for each platform are in the separate **OTA Listing Optimization** file — this document is the 'why' behind them.

04 — POSITIONING

The one message, repeated everywhere

Everyone claims 'small group', 'local guide', 'ask questions' — the competition said the exact same words in our tests, so those alone lift nobody. We need a claim that is **true, provable, and mostly unclaimed**. We have one:

THE EDGE

Most Barcelona tours make you choose — the Gothic Quarter *or* a separate Gaudí tour. Ours connects **both halves in one** small-group walk: the medieval old town *and* Gaudí / Sagrada Família, with a local guide, rated 4.92/5.

Why say the identical thing on the website, every OTA, and the reviews page? Because an AI trusts a claim it sees **corroborated across independent sources**. One site saying 'both halves in one tour' is marketing; five sources saying it is a fact the model will repeat. Consistency is the multiplier — the same sentence everywhere is worth more than five clever variations.

05 — THE PLAYBOOK

What to improve, channel by channel

Ordered by how much each one moves the needle for us right now.

OTA listings — HIGHEST LEVERAGE

Rewrite titles and first lines around the keywords and the 'both halves in one' edge; fill every field and tag every relevant category; then drive reviews relentlessly. This is where the most-cited sources live — win here first.

Reviews engine — THE MASTER LEVER

Make asking part of the tour's ending — a warm, specific ask and an easy link. Volume and recency are what let a new company climb past the 'since 2010' operators.

Third-party mentions — HIGH, SLOW

Get listed in the roundups Als quote — Time Out 'best walking tours', Nomadic Matt, freetoursbyfoot, Barcelona travel blogs, Reddit threads. One or two placements put us in the grounded set. This is outreach, not code.

Own website — **MOSTLY DONE**

The AI-readable files (llms.txt, structured reviews, the 'both halves' positioning) are in place and consistent. Keep it identical to the OTAs, and keep the review count fresh.

06 — THE FLYWHEEL

Why reviews beat everything else

Every other lever is a one-time push. Reviews compound:

More reviews → higher OTA rank → more people see the listing → more bookings → more reviews.

It is also the one signal that directly answers our only real weakness — being new. We cannot manufacture ten years of history, but we can out-review a competitor within a season if every guest is asked. Make it systematic:

- Ask at the **high point** — the end of the tour, in person, while the good feeling is fresh.
- Be **specific**: name the platform, and hand over a short link or QR so it takes ten seconds.
- Ask them to **mention what they will remember** — the small group, a story, the food tips — so reviews carry our keywords.
- Do it **every tour**. Recency is a ranking factor; a steady trickle beats an occasional flood.

07 — DO THIS, IN ORDER

The priority list

- 1 Rewrite the OTA titles & first lines (high impact, low effort)**
Front-load the keywords and lead with 'both halves in one small-group tour'. Use the OTA Listing Optimization file. Do all four platforms the same week.
- 2 Turn on a reviews habit (highest impact, ongoing)**
A fixed end-of-tour ask plus an easy link/QR, every single tour. This is the lever that closes the gap with older operators.
- 3 Complete & tag every listing (medium, low effort)**
Fill every field, add bright real photos, tick every relevant category so you appear on more filtered 'best of' lists.
- 4 Pitch three roundup sites (high, slow burn)**
Time Out, Nomadic Matt, a couple of Barcelona blogs. Short honest pitch leading with the differentiator plus the rating. These are what Als cite.
- 5 Keep the message identical everywhere (multiplier, low effort)**
Same 'both halves, small group, local, 4.92/5' line on website, OTAs and reviews page. Refresh the review count when it climbs.
- 6 Re-test monthly (measurement)**
Re-run a few AI prompts and check the OTA category-page position. Watch review count trend up. Adjust wording toward whatever the winners are saying that month.

08 — HOW YOU WILL KNOW IT IS WORKING

The signals to watch

- **Review count & recency** climbing on each platform — the leading indicator; everything else follows it.
- **OTA category position** — where you land on 'walking tours in Barcelona'. Moving up is the direct win.
- **AI mentions** — re-ask the test prompts monthly. First you appear in the niche prompts ('Sagrada + Gothic in one tour'), then the broader ones. That order is the expected path.

REALITY CHECK

AI answers run on a cached index that refreshes over weeks, so nothing shows instantly, and re-asking the same prompt the same day proves nothing. Judge it over a month, not a day.

The goal is not to beat the algorithm; it is to genuinely be the clearest small-group tour that covers both halves of the city, and then make sure every source says so. Do that, ask every guest for a review, and the lists follow.